



THE ECONOMY

China has shifted from a centrally planned to a market-oriented economy; liberalization has gone furthest in the south where the emerging business class is based. The Tenth Five-Year Plan (2001–2005) emphasized rapid development; the Eleventh Plan aims to reduce wealth disparities. Exports led sustained GDP growth from 2003; China has become the world's third-largest

economy. Faced with a global downturn from 2008, Chinese stimulus packages have boosted domestic spending. The buying power of China's huge market for raw materials and consumer goods could drive global recovery.



INSIGHT: *China has the world's oldest continuous civilization. Its recorded history began 4000 years ago, with the Shang dynasty*

